

01

## SĀṂKHYA DUALISM, PRAMĀṆAS AND COGNITION

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Sāṁkhya accepts perception, inference and reliable testimony as pramāṇas, using inference to establish supersensible Prakṛti and Puruṣa.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The internal organ takes the form of an object and appears conscious when Puruṣa's awareness is reflected in it.

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Experience is possible without making matter conscious or consciousness an agent, but the relation between the two principles becomes the system's central difficulty.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not identify Puruṣa with mind, ego or buddhi, because all three psychological functions belong to evolved Prakṛti.

**ANSWER LINE:** The system's epistemology supports its dualism: cognition belongs to the material internal organ, while consciousness belongs to the witnessing Puruṣa.

02

## PRAKṚTI, THE THREE GUṆAS AND THEIR PROOFS

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Prakṛti (prakṛiti) is the unmanifest, unconscious, primordial material principle from which the entire objective and psycho-physical world evolves. □ It is also called pradhāna (chief principle) because it is the primary material basis of all empirical manifestation. □ It is called avyakta (unmanifest) because in its primordial condition it is not yet differentiated into manifest tattvas. □ It is not a created entity; it is the ultimate material cause of the world within Sāṁkhya's dualist ontology. □□ In exam language, Prakṛti is not merely "matter" in the modern physicalist sense; it includes the roots of intellect, ego, mind, senses, subtle elements and gross elements.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Pradhāna emphasizes that Prakṛti is the chief material principle. □ Avyakta emphasizes that it is unmanifest prior to differentiated evolution. □□ An exam-safe definition: Prakṛti is the avyakta pradhāna, the unmanifest chief material principle constituted by the three guṇas.

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The standard cluster of arguments is central to UPSC. □ Empirical things are many, finite, delimited and measurable. □ What is finite and determinate points beyond itself to a more fundamental source from which such determinate forms arise. □ The manifold world therefore requires a common antecedent material ground. □□ The force of the argument is not merely "every effect has a cause," but "the limited and differentiated presuppose a subtler ground from which limitation and differentiation emerge." □ Effects display an underlying order and common pattern. □ Diverse products nevertheless reveal continuity of constitution and dependence. □ Such systematic coherence suggests a common material basis. □□ This is an argument from coordinated diversity: if effects hang together, they are likely rooted in one underlying matrix. □ The empirical order is not inert chaos; it is a field of production, activity and transformation. □ Productive activity presupposes a causal potency capable of issuing in determinate effects. □ Therefore there must be an underlying productive principle possessing the capacity for manifestation. □□ Sāṁkhya here reasons from the fact of becoming to an abiding source of becoming. □ Cause and effect are distinguishable stages: the unmanifest source and the manifest product are not identical in appearance. □ If effects are manifest, multiple and differentiated, their cause must be a more basic, prior and subtler condition. □ Thus the manifest order implies an unmanifest causal matrix distinct from it as cause from effect. □□ The point is not total disconnection: cause and effect are distinguishable without being unrelated. □ The world is astonishingly diverse, yet this diversity forms one interconnected cosmos. □ A diversified whole points back to an undivided source in which later differentiations are not yet separated. □ Therefore there must be an original unmanifest, undivided root of the whole world-process. □ This is the proof that shows Prakṛti must be ONE. □ UPSC 2019 directly tests this point: if the diversity of the world issues from an undivided source, that source cannot itself be many disconnected material ultimates; it must be singular. □□ This is the strongest anti-pluralist argument at the level of material causation in Sāṁkhya.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Before manifestation, the three guṇas exist in equilibrium called sāmyāvasthā. □ In this state Prakṛti is avyakta, unmanifest. □ Manifest evolution begins when this equilibrium is disturbed in the presence of Puruṣa. □□ Disturbance should not be imagined as mechanical collision; Sāṁkhya speaks of functional activation in proximity.

**ANSWER LINE:** "Puruṣa (the pure conscious witness) is inactive, non-objectifiable and distinct from every product of Prakṛti, while jīva (the empirical embodied self) is Puruṣa apparently identified with intellect, ego and the subtle body."

03

## PURUṢA, ITS PLURALITY AND THE WITNESS PRINCIPLE

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Reply. □ Sāṁkhya replies that agency belongs to Prakṛti's evolutes; ascribing agency to Puruṣa is precisely the abhīmāna that bondage consists in.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Statement. □ Sāṁkhya argues for Puruṣa as a distinct conscious principle because the entire objective complex is unconscious, instrumental and presented to experience.

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Conclusion. □ This is not a God-proof; it is an inference to Puruṣa as the presiding witness of lived order.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Distinction. □□ Plurality does not mean qualitative difference among Puruṣas; each Puruṣa is pure, inactive consciousness, but they are numerically many.

**ANSWER LINE:** Pure consciousness, being without attribute, part, action or spatial location, admits no principle of individuation; therefore Sāṁkhya proves at most a plurality of cittas (mental streams), not Puruṣas.

04

## THE TWENTY-FIVE TATTVAS AND COSMIC EVOLUTION

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Rājas supplies activity, energy and operative force to both lines. □ Rājasa ahaṁkāra does not produce a separate set of tattvas. □□ This must be written explicitly because it is repeatedly confused.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Buddhi determines, judges, ascertains and discriminates. □ It is the locus where reflected consciousness is most conspicuous in empirical life. □□ In psychology, manas coordinates, ahaṁkāra appropriates, buddhi determines.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: □ Ahaṁkāra is the I-maker, the principle of individuation. □ It appropriates functions into...

**ANSWER LINE:** □ Mahat and buddhi are the SAME tattva. □ Mahat is the cosmic aspect or name. □ Buddhi is the individual/psychological aspect or name. □ Ahaṁkāra emerges from buddhi/mahat as the principle of individuation or I-sense. □ Therefore the sequence is Prakṛti → mahat/buddhi → ahaṁkāra. □□ This is a classic UPSC trap.

05

## SATKĀRYAVĀDA, PARIṆĀMAVĀDA AND RIVAL CAUSAL THEORIES

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Statement. □ Sāṁkhya's satkāryavāda is specifically pariṇāmavāda: the effect is a real transformation of the cause.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that □ Satkāryavāda holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause. □ Production is...

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Statement. □ Sāṁkhya's satkāryavāda is specifically pariṇāmavāda: the effect is a real transformation of the cause.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: reply. □□ Sāṁkhya replies that causal capacity in the required determinate sense just is...

**ANSWER LINE:** □ Satkāryavāda holds that the effect pre-exists in its material cause. □ Production is manifestation, not creation out of sheer non-being. □ Sāṁkhya's specific form of satkāryavāda is pariṇāmavāda, the doctrine of real transformation.

06

## BONDAGE, DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE AND KAIVALYA

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Bondage in Sāṁkhya is aviveka, non-discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti. □ Buddhi reflects consciousness, and this reflection creates false identification. □ The self then appears as agent, enjoyer, sufferer and knower in the empirical sense. □□ Bondage is not real alteration in Puruṣa but mistaken identification through reflected consciousness.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Prakṛti is like a dancer who stops after being seen by Puruṣa. □ Once discriminative knowledge arises, Prakṛti no longer continues its binding display for that Puruṣa. □□ This is the neatest canonical image for liberation through fulfilled disclosure.

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### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Puruṣa is like the lame: conscious but inactive. □ Prakṛti is like the blind: active but unconscious. □ Together they explain empirical process. □□ The analogy conveys complementarity without collapsing the two principles into one.

**ANSWER LINE:** □ Liberation is viveka-jñāna, discriminative knowledge that "I am not Prakṛti." □ When the distinction between witness-consciousness and guṇic evolutes becomes steady, false identification ends. □ This state is kaivalya, the aloneness or isolation of Puruṣa. □□ Kaivalya is not merger; it is disentanglement.

07

## THE CONTACT PROBLEM AND ŚAṂKARA'S CRITIQUE

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ Sāṁkhya answers that the relation is sannidhya, mere proximity or presence, not gross physical contact. □ Puruṣa does not push or alter Prakṛti by action. □ Prakṛti becomes active in the mere presence of Puruṣa.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ Unconscious prakṛti cannot be the Upaniṣadic cause because the Upaniṣadic source is described as conscious, knowing and sat-cit in character. □ The contact problem remains unresolved: inactive Puruṣa and unconscious Prakṛti cannot intelligibly relate. □ Teleology cannot be explained without consciousness: if Prakṛti evolves "for the sake of" Puruṣa, purposiveness seems to require intelligence. □ Texts describing the cause as knowing (tajjñāh-type descriptions) exclude jada-prakṛti. □ UPSC 2025 makes this a 20-marker shared with Vedānta.md.

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### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Śaṁkara argues that if Puruṣa is truly inactive and Prakṛti truly unconscious, no intelligible real relation is possible. □ The magnet analogy fails because even a magnet exerts force; if Puruṣa were like that, it would not be wholly inactive. □ The crystal analogy may explain appearance, but not the initiation of world-process. □ Therefore Sāṁkhya dualism appears unstable: either it collapses toward monism or it requires a third mediating principle. □ UPSC 2023 directly tests this critique of Sāṁkhya dualism.

**ANSWER LINE:** "Sāṁkhya (the enumerative dualist school) integrates psychology, cosmology and liberation without a creator God, yet guṇa-explanation risks elasticity, Puruṣa-plurality lacks a clear individuator, and mere proximity does not fully solve the contact problem."

08

## INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES, OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Inter-School Debates, Objections And Replies is analysed by relating Inter-School Debates to Objections, then testing the relationship through Replies and Priority.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ How can unconscious Prakṛti evolve purposively for Puruṣa's sake? □ Sāṁkhya reply: purposive functioning need not involve conscious planning; the guṇa-structure itself yields ordered manifestation in the presence of Puruṣa. □□ This reply preserves system-internal sufficiency but remains vulnerable to Vedāntic criticism. □ If Puruṣa and Prakṛti are radically different, how can misidentification occur? □ Sāṁkhya reply: through proximity, reflection and false attribution rather than real fusion. □□ This is partly explanatory and partly analogical; critics see it as the school's weakest point. □ Could not one consciousness appear as many? □ Sāṁkhya reply: non-simultaneous liberation, individual experience and differentiated embodiment support plurality. □ If effect already exists, production is redundant. □ Sāṁkhya reply: production is manifestation from latent to patent, not pointless repetition.

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Priority: Primary ownership rises to 10 of 112 parts and occurs in every year. □ Required doctrinal depth: The restored questions require plurality of Puruṣas, a defence of Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda against Advaita and application of satkāryavāda to the mango-seed example while rejecting rival causation theories. □ Trap / answer consequence: Do not confuse one Prakṛti with one Puruṣa, or say the gross tree pre-exists visibly in the seed; reconstruct latent effect, material continuity and transformation.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: rival - exact objection - Sāṁkhya reply - residual force.

**ANSWER LINE:** "The power of Sāṁkhya (the enumerative dualist school) lies in connecting epistemology, material continuity, empirical consciousness and liberation within one system; its weakness is that the relation required to connect its two absolutes remains under-explained."

09

## PRESUPPOSITIONS, COMPARISONS AND GRADED VERDICT

### CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Sāṁkhya vs Advaita on satkāryavāda. □□ Both can be treated as satkāryavādins because both deny sheer creation from non-being; the decisive difference is pariṇāma versus vivarta.

### MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Sāṁkhya vs Advaita on satkāryavāda. □□ Both can be treated as satkāryavādins because both deny sheer creation from non-being; the decisive difference is pariṇāma versus vivarta.

### CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

20 marks. □□ Sāṁkhya is a philosophically serious non-theistic system whose causal realism and psychology of reflection are impressive, but whose unconscious teleology and plurality of attributeless Puruṣas remain unresolved pressure points.

### UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A web result claiming adoption of a national "Sāṁkhya Paradigm" in mental-health policy was not supported by an official government source and is excluded.

**ANSWER LINE:** "A high-scoring Sāṁkhya (enumerative dualist school) answer should state the dualist thesis, present the exact proof or evolutionary sequence, confront the contact or teleology objection, and conclude with a qualified verdict rather than a slogan."